The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

Donald Trump announced that a ceasefire between **Israel** and **Lebanon** would be extended for three weeks, after he hosted diplomats from the countries at the White House. Hizbullah, the Iran-backed militant group that Israel is fighting in Lebanon, has not commented on the announcement. Soon afterwards Israel's ambassador to the UN said the ceasefire was "not 100%", accusing Hizbullah of firing rockets at Israel.

Mr Trump reiterated that America would maintain its **naval blockade** until Iran makes a deal, adding that he wasn't in a "rush" to reach an agreement. He also said he had ordered America's navy to "shoot and kill" boats putting mines in the **Strait of Hormuz**. Iran has attacked at least three ships in the waterway and said it had detained two others since Mr Trump extended a ceasefire on Tuesday.

Meta will cut about 10% of its workforce—around 8,000 jobs—as it shifts resources towards artificial intelligence. Mark Zuckerberg, the company's boss, has warned that AI tools could replace some work done by engineers. Meanwhile Microsoft, which is also spending lots on AI, reportedly offered voluntary redundancy to about 7% of its staff in America.

Intel's shares jumped by about 20% after the American semiconductor giant reported stronger-than-expected first-quarter results and forecast robust sales for the current quarter. Demand for the chips used in data centres is rising as companies invest heavily in AI. The boom is helping Intel recover after years of falling behind rivals.

America's **Department of Commerce** said it would impose provisional tariffs on **solar** cells and panels from **India, Indonesia and Laos**, accusing producers of selling below fair value. The duties vary widely—reaching over 120% for some Indian imports—and mark the latest escalation in a years-long campaign against cheap solar equipment from Asia.

The **European Union** approved a €90bn ($105bn) loan to **Ukraine**, and a 20th package of sanctions against Russia. Two-thirds of the loan is for defence spending. The package had been held up for months by Hungary and Slovakia, which had demanded that Ukraine repair the Druzhba pipeline, which supplies Russian oil to Europe via Ukraine. It finished repairs on Tuesday.

America's Department of Justice charged a soldier with using classified information to bet on the capture of Nicolás Maduro, Venezuela's former leader, on **Polymarket**, a prediction market. Sergeant Gannon Ken Van Dyke allegedly made more than $400,000 from wagers on the operation. The DOJ called it "clear insider trading". Polymarket said it had flagged the bets to authorities and that the arrest was "proof" its monitoring system works.

Figure of the day: $585m, the value of Chinese whisky sold overseas last year, up from $5m a decade earlier. Read more about how the tipple is thriving.

Photograph: Reuters

Chinese EVs in the fast lane

Hundreds of thousands of visitors and hundreds of exhibitors will race to Beijing this weekend for one of the world's biggest motor shows. Over ten days at the Beijing Auto Show, Chinese battery- and EV-makers will debut new models and technologies. Ahead of the show CATL, the world's largest battery-maker, unveiled a new battery that it claims can be recharged from 10% to 90% in six minutes, beating BYD's best effort of nine. (Both say their batteries deliver around 1,000km of range.)

The show comes at an opportune moment. The war in Iran has pushed up petrol prices, making alternatives more desirable. But China's EV market has descended into a savage, three-year price war, caused by chronic overcapacity. As a result, Chinese automakers are increasingly looking to go global. China already makes roughly 70% of the world's EVs and 85% of its battery-cells. The Beijing Auto Show will reveal how much further its firms are pulling ahead of the pack.

Photograph: AP

Not so sweet Virginia

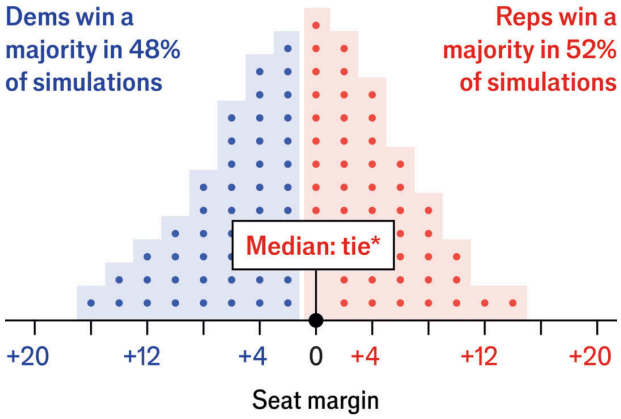
The Republican Party's hopes of maintaining control of America's House of Representatives were already slim. Voters in Virginia may have destroyed them. On Tuesday they passed a referendum that will gerrymander three or four of the party's incumbents out of their seats. In *The Economist's* statistical forecast of this year's Congressional elections, the result in Virginia increased Democrats' average expected seats in the 435-seat chamber from 232 to 235, and their probability of a majority from 94% to 98%.

The Senate, meanwhile, is on a knife's edge. The list of seats up for election favours Republicans: Democrats need to gain four for a majority, including in at least two states that Donald Trump won by double digits in 2024. Don't count the Democrats out yet, though. They lead national polls by six percentage points. They have also recruited strong candidates in Alaska, North Carolina and Ohio. Our model suggests the Dems have a 48% chance of flipping both chambers.

US Senate forecast

At Apr 22nd 2026

One dot=100 simulated elections



*The Republican vice-president, J.D. Vance, breaks ties

Source: *The Economist*'s midterm election model

Photograph: EPA

What sort of change will America bring about in Cuba?

America's deadline for Cuba to release some political prisoners is Friday. That is one of several demands, not all of them clearly stated, that the Trump administration is making of Cuba's communist regime. It imposed an oil blockade on the island in January. The two governments reportedly held secret talks on April 10th in Havana. If Cuba releases the prisoners further negotiations may take place. If not, the Trump administration may increase the pressure.

Among its demands is reform of Cuba's centrally-planned economy. Most Cubans would welcome that. Now they suffer from food shortages, power cuts and deteriorating health care, all of which are made worse by the blockade. Liberalisation would also provide opportunities for American business. Less clear is whether the Trump administration means to force the regime out of power. Its leaders are savvy: they will try to lessen the pressure by making concessions while seeking to stay in control.

Photograph: Lionsgate

“Michael”: it’s Bad

A film about an eccentric megastar—who made fans swoon and befriended a chimpanzee—should not be dull. Yet “Michael”, a biopic of Michael Jackson released in American cinemas on Friday, contrives to be. Starring the singer’s nephew, Jaafar Jackson, it recounts the rise of the Jackson 5, then Michael’s struggle to escape his despotic father, Joseph (Colman Domingo), while accumulating exotic pets and idolising Peter Pan. As Jackson is to his devotees, this version of him is a saint, whose destiny is to “spread love and joy” and “heal” people.

The main event is the music, which is as wondrous as ever. Despite the allegations of child abuse that dogged Jackson in the years before his death in 2009, his greatest songs have proved uncancellable. Since the plot ends before those accusations emerged, they go unmentioned in this nauseating movie. “His story continues,” reads a closing note. Indeed it did.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which medieval kingdom in the Persian gulf was ruled by descendants of Muhammad Diramku?

Thursday: Which Malaysian state is bordered by Negeri Sembilan to the north and Johor to the east?

The lack of a sense of history is the damnation of the modern world.

Robert Penn Warren